# Here Come Da Judge from The Shack

## By William Paul Young

## INTRODUCTION

*Our story begins with Mackenzie "Mack" Phillips, a father suffering great pain because of the death of his young daughter at the hands of a serial killer. Mack receives a note from "Papa" to meet him at the rundown shack in the woods where police had found evidence of his daughter's murder six years earlier. Mack, who was raised by a hypocritical, vicious and abusive father who was also a pastor, already understands from previous experience that "Papa" is God. The following scene occurs midway through the book after Mack has already met: (in the character of Papa) Papa -- a large beaming African-American woman; (in the character of Jesus) Jesus -- a Middle Eastern man dressed as a laborer; (in the character of the Holy Spirit) And the Holy Spirit -- a woman of Asian ethnicity. It is the Holy Spirit who walks Mack through "The Judgment"*

*Here Come Da Judge from The Shack by William Paul Young*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

**WOMAN:** Do you understand why you are here?

**MACK:** You know . . . *(quietly)* I have no idea. No one told me.

**WOMAN:** *(laughing)* Well, Mackenzie Allen Phillips. I am here to help you. *(Mack chuckles too, not even knowing or caring why).* Today is a very serious day with very serious consequences. *(pause)* Mackenzie, you are here, in part, because of your children, but you are also here for . . .

**MACK:** *(Interrupting)* My children? What do you mean I'm here because of my children?

**WOMAN:** Mackenzie, you love your children in a way that your own father was never able to love you and your sisters. Some parents are too broken to love their children well and others are barely able to love them at all, you should understand that. But you, you do love your children well-very well. So then, Mackenzie, may I ask which of your children do you love the most?

**MACK:** *(smiling)* I don't love any one of them more than any of the others. I love each of them differently. *(choosing his words carefully)*

**WOMAN:** Explain that to me, Mackenzie.

**MACK:** I remember after Jon, my first, was born. I was so captivated by the wonder of who this little life was that I actually worried about whether I would have anything left to love a second child. But when Tyler came along, it was as if he brought with him a special gift for me, a whole new capacity to love him specially.

**WOMAN:** Well said, Mackenzie! But what about when they do not behave, or they make choices other than those you would want them to make, or they are just belligerent and rude? What about when they embarrass you in front of others? How does that affect your love for them?

**MACK:** *(slowly and deliberately)* It doesn't, really. I admit that it does affect me and sometimes I get embarrassed or angry, but even when they act badly, they are still my son or my daughter, they are still Josh or Kate, and they will be forever. What they do might affect my pride, but not my love for them.

**WOMAN:** *(beaming)* You are wise in the ways of real love, Mackenzie. So many believe that it is love that grows, but it is the *knowing* that grows and love simply expands to contain it. Love is just the skin of knowing. Mackenzie, you love your children, whom you know so well, with a wonderful and real love.

**MACK:** *(embarrassed, looking down)* Well, thanks, but I'm not that way with very many other people. My love tends to be pretty conditional most of the time.

**WOMAN:** But it's a start, isn't it, Mackenzie? And you didn't move beyond your father's inability on your own, it was God and you together who changed you to love this way. And now you love your children much the way Father loves his. *(Mack's anger rises, he tries to cover his emotions, but he is clearly angry)* Hmmmmm.

Something I said bother you, Mackenzie? *(pause)* Mackenzie? Is there something you would like to say?

**MACK:** Uh . . . . well, no! Not really

**WOMAN:** Mackenzie, this is a time for honesty, for truth. You don't believe that Father loves his children very well, do you? You don't truly believe that God is good, do you?

**MACK:** *(snapping)* Is Missy his child?

**WOMAN:** Of course!

**MACK:** Then, no! *(unable to stay still – angry and ready to explode)* I don't believe that God loves all his children very well!

**WOMAN:** Mackenzie. Earlier, I began to tell you why you are here today. Not only are you here because of your children, but you are here for judgment. *(Mack panics, feels guilty with no defense for his past sins)* Mackenzie?

**MACK:** No I understand. I'm dead, aren't I? That's why I can see Jesus and Papa, cuz I'm dead. *(pause)* I can't believe it! I didn't even feel anything. *(pause)* How long have I been dead?

**WOMAN:** Mackenzie, I am sorry to disappoint you, but you have not yet fallen asleep in your world, and I believe that you have mis-

**MACK:** *(cutting her off)* I'm not dead? You mean all this is real and I'm still alive? But I thought you said I came here for judgment?

**WOMAN:** *(matter of factly)* I did. But, Macken-

**MACK:** Judgement? And I'm not even dead? *(anger replacing his panic)* This hardly seems fair! Does this happen to other people-getting judged, I mean, before they're even dead? What if I change? What if I do better the rest of my life? What if I repent? What then?"

**WOMAN:** *(unfazed by his outburst)* Is there something you wish to repent of, Mackenzie?

**MACK:** *(shaking his head slowly)* I wouldn't know where to begin. I'm quite a mess, aren't I?

**WOMAN:** *(smiling)* Yes, you are. You are a glorious, destructive mess, Mackenzie, but you are not here to repent, at least not in the way that you understand. Mackenzie, you are not here to be judged.

**MACK:** *(interrupting again)* But, I thought you said that I was . . .

**WOMAN:** . . . here for judgment? I did. But *you* are not on trial here. *(Mack takes a deep breath, relieved)* You will be the Judge!

**MACK:** What? Me? I'd rather not. *(pause)* I don't have any ability to judge.

**WOMAN:** Oh, that is not true. *(with a hint of sarcasm)* You have judged many throughout your life. You have judged the actions and even the motivations of others, as if you somehow knew what those were in truth. You have judged the color of skin and body language and body odor. You have judged history and relationships. You have even judged the value of a person's life by the quality of your concept of beauty. By all accounts, you are quite well-practiced in the activity. *(Mack's face reddens with shame . . . looks down)* Tell me, if I may ask, by what criteria do you base your judgments?

**MACK:** *(unable to make eye contact)* Nothing that seems to make much sense at the moment. *(his voice faltering)* I confess that when I made those judgments I felt quite justified, but now . . .

**WOMAN:** Of course you did. *(a statement of fact)* Judging requires that you think yourself superior over the one you judge. Well, today you will be given the opportunity to put all your ability to use.

**MACK:** And . . . . just what will I be judging?

**WOMAN:** Not what. Who. *(Mack starts to panic – it is obvious in his nervous gestures and on his face)* Your imagination is not serving you well at his moment.

**MACK:** *(weakly)* I really can't do this.

**WOMAN:** *(smiling)* Whether you can or cannot is yet to be determined.

**MACK:** So, who is it that I am supposed to judge?

**WOMAN:** God. *(pause, then finishes as if it was of no particular consequence)* And the human race.

**MACK:** *(dumbfounded)* You have got to be kidding!

**WOMAN:** Why not? Surely there are many people in your world you think deserve judgment. There must be at least a few who are to blame for so much of the pain and suffering? What about the greedy who feed off the poor of the world? What about the ones who sacrifice their young children to war? What about the men who beat their wives, Mackenzie? What about the fathers who beat their sons for no reason but to assuage their own suffering? Don't they deserve judgment, Mackenzie? *(Mack clenches his fist, breathing coming short and quick as he tries to control his unresolved anger)* And what about the man who preys on innocent little girls? What about him, Mackenzie? Is that man guilty? Should he be judged?

**MACK:** *(screaming)* Yes! Damn him to hell!

**WOMAN:** Is he to blame for your loss?

**MACK:** Yes!

**WOMAN:** What about his father, the man who twisted his son into a terror, what about him?

**MACK:** Yes, him too!

**WOMAN:** How far do we go back, Mackenzie? This legacy of brokenness goes all the way back to Adam, what about him? But why stop there? What about God? God started this whole thing. Is God to blame? *(continues unrelenting)* Isn't this where you are stuck, Mackenzie? Isn't this what fuels *The Great Sadness?* That God cannot be trusted? Surely, a father like you can judge *the* Father! *(Mack's anger continues to rise)* Isn't that your just

complaint, Mackenzie? That God has failed you, that he failed Missy? That before the Creation, God knew that one day your Missy would be brutalized, and still he created? And then he *allowed* that twisted soul to snatch her from your loving arms when he had the power to stop him. Isn't God to blame, Mackenzie?

**MACK:** *(loudly, pointing his finger right at her)* Yes! God is to blame!

**WOMAN:** Then, if you are able to judge God so easily, then you certainly can judge the world. *(without emotion)* You must choose two of your children to spend eternity in God's new heavens and new earth, but only two.

**MACK;** What? *(beginning to panic)*

**WOMAN:** And you must choose three of your children to spend eternity in hell. *(pause, then continues calmly)* Mackenzie. I am only asking you to do something that you believe God does. He knows every person ever conceived, and he knows them so much deeper and clearer than you will ever know your own children. He loves each one according to his knowledge of the being of that son or daughter. You believe he will condemn most to an eternity of torment, away from His presence and apart from His love. Is that not true?

**MACK:** I suppose I do. I've just never thought about it like this. *(stumbling over his words, in shock)* I just assumed that somehow God could do that. Talking about hell was always sort of an abstract conversation, not about anyone that I truly . . . not about anyone that I truly cared about.

**WOMAN:** So you suppose, then, that God does this easily, but you cannot? Come now, Mackenzie. Which three of your five children will you sentence to hell? Katie is struggling with you the most right now. She treats you badly and has said hurtful things to you. Perhaps she is the first and most logical choice. What about her? You are the judge, Mackenzie and you must choose.

**MACK:** I don't want to be the judge . . . *(softly)* I can't do this.

**WOMAN:** You must.

**MACK:** *(louder and more vehemently)* I can't do this.

**WOMAN:** *(very softly)* You must.

**MACK:** *(yelling)* I . . . will . . . not . . . do . . . this!

**WOMAN:** *(whispering)* You must.

**MACK:** *(Screaming, completely out of control)* I can't. I can't. I won't! *(The woman stands silently watching and waiting) (After a long pause)* Could I go instead? If you need someone to torture for eternity, I'll go in their place. Would that work? Could I do that? *(Crying and begging)* Please let me go for my children, please, I would be happy to . . . Please, I am begging you. Please . . . Please . . .

**WOMAN:** *(softly and smiling)* Mackenzie, Mackenzie. Now you sound like Jesus. You have judged well, Mackenzie. I am so proud of you.

**MACK:** *(confused)* But I haven't judged anything.

**WOMAN:** Oh, but you have. You have judged them worthy of love, even if it cost you everything. That is how Jesus loves. And now you know Papa's heart, who loves all his children perfectly. *(Mack bristles as an image of Missy flashes through his mind – the change is obviously back to anger)* What just happened, Mackenzie?

**MACK:** I understand Jesus' love, but God is another story. I don't find them to be alike at all. I just don't understand how God could love Missy and let her go through that horror. She was innocent. She didn't do anything to deserve that. Did God use her to punish me for what I did to my father? That isn't fair. She didn't deserve this. *(crying)* I might have, but she didn't.

**WOMAN:** Is that who your God is, Mackenzie? It is no wonder you are drowning in your sorrow. Papa isn't like that, Mackenzie. She's not punishing you, or Missy. This was not his doing.

**MACK:** But he didn't stop it.

**WOMAN:** No, he didn't. He doesn't stop a lot of things that cause him pain. Your world is severely broken. You demanded your independence, and now you are angry with the one who loved you enough to give it to you. Nothing is as it should be, as Papa desires it to be, and as it will be one day. Right now your world is lost in darkness and chaos, and horrible things happen to those that he is especially fond of.

**MACK:** Then why doesn't he do something about it?

**WOMAN:** He already has . . . *(smiling)* He chose the way of the cross where mercy triumphs over justice because of love. Would you instead prefer he'd chosen justice for everyone? Do you want justice, 'Dear Judge'?

**MACK:** No, I don't. Not for me and not for my children. *(pause)* But I still don't understand why Missy had to die.

**WOMAN:** She didn't have to, Mackenzie. This was no plan of Papa's. Papa has never needed evil to accomplish his good purposes. It is you humans who have embraced evil and Papa has responded with goodness. What happened to Missy was the work of evil and no one in your world is immune from it.

**MACK:** But it hurts so much. There must be a better way.

**WOMAN:** There is. You just can't see it now. Return from your independence, Mackenzie. Give up being his judge and know Papa for who he is. Then you will be able to embrace his love in the midst of your pain, instead of pushing him away with your self-centered perception of how you think the universe should be. Papa has crawled inside of your world to be with you, to be with Missy.

**MACK:** I don't want to be a judge any more. I really do want to trust Papa. But I'll need help.

**WOMAN:** Now that sounds like the start of the trip home, Mackenzie. It certainly does.

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author:  William Paul Young***
***Book:  The Shack***
***ISBN:  978-0964729230***
***Publisher: Windblown Media***
***Date (Month/Year):  July 2007***

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY